Alaap

An AI front desk for India's small shops · "Har call ka jawab"

The Great Indian AI Internship Challenge
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github.com/AshmitCajla/alaap

THE PROBLEM

India's salons, clinics, kiranas and coaching centres run on phone calls, and most have one person to answer them. Calls go unanswered while the owner serves someone at the counter, after closing time, or when two phones ring at once, and a missed call is often a booking that goes to the shop next door. Menu-based IVRs and English chatbots don't fit customers who speak Hindi, Punjabi and the mix in between.

THE SOLUTION

Alaap answers every call, WhatsApp message and web chat like a trained receptionist, in the customer's own language. It checks real free slots and stock, books appointments, takes orders with UPI payment links, logs complaints, qualifies leads, and passes anything it can't solve to the owner on WhatsApp. Owners see everything in a dashboard and change prices or timings by simply telling it ("Facial ka rate 900 kar do"). Shops can set it up in minutes from a photo of their rate card, or the Alaap team sets it up for them and lends them a phone number.

HOW GNANI AI POWERS THE VOICE

GNANI PRISMA · STT

Hears the caller

- Streaming recognition over WebSocket, live on every call
- Hindi, Punjabi, English and code-mixed speech (indic-auto, codemix)
- Its voice-activity detection ends each turn; shop's service names sent as keyterms

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GEMINI · REASONING

Decides and acts

- Tool calls: free slots, bookings, orders, complaints, leads
- Reads back and saves only after a clear "yes"
- Answers only from the shop's own data; never invents prices

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GNANI TIMBRE · TTS

Speaks the reply

- Streamed sentence by sentence, so it starts talking early
- 13 voices; numbers spoken naturally ("saade chhe baje")
- WhatsApp voice notes: Prisma transcribes, Timbre replies

BUILT TO BE TRUSTED

Safe actions	Every booking/order is checked in code, read back, and confirmed only after the customer replies.
Correct under load	Database row locks: no double bookings or overselling (tested with 20 simultaneous confirmations).
Security	Per-shop data isolation; only real caller ID unlocks a customer's bookings; signed webhooks.
Tested	44 automated tests, live conversation checks against the real models, and an end-to-end voice-call test.
Stack	FastAPI · Next.js · Postgres · Redis · Docker + Caddy (HTTPS) · Exotel, WhatsApp Cloud API, Razorpay.

STATUS AND NEXT STEPS

Working MVP	Live voice calls in the browser, web chat, owner dashboard, Ask Alaap, team console, billing. Demo: a real call books a slot end to end (video, 2:56).
Honest numbers	On free-tier Gemini, the caller hears Riya 2.3–3.0 s after speaking and her answer in 2.6–4.9 s; a paid tier should bring this down.
Next	Connect the Exotel phone line and WhatsApp Business API, then pilot with 10 shops in Patiala.
Business model	Monthly plans ₹999 / ₹2,499 / ₹5,999 with a 14-day trial; done-for-you setup for owners who won't touch a dashboard.

Impact: a small shop gets a front desk that never misses a call, speaks its customers' language, and never invents a price, for the cost of a few days of a helper's wages a month. The owner gets every booking, order and complaint on WhatsApp.